means the giving of one's head for a higher gain. Bismil was not alone in extolling the virtues of sacrifice to the extent of embracing *shahidee*. In her insightful analysis, Simona Sawhney draws attention to 'the figure of Shaheed, the one who bears witness to the truth of the nation and stands by that truth, even unto death'. We can 'recall that the word Shaheed in Arabic, means much like "Martus" in Greek, initially refers to the witness', so that in this way, '[t]he epithet "Shaheed" is often associated with Bhagat Singh and other nationalist heroes of that time'. This allows us to understand how '[i]n Bismil's poem, the Shaheed stands out as a figure to be emulated'.[3] She continues, 'In Bismil's poem the hero gains his true life – his life as a hero – only in death.'[4] Since '[i]n such a dream, the *qatil*, or the murderer, becomes almost the accomplice of the Shaheed – less an antagonist, and more an ally', Bhagat Singh also has to die. In the same way, '[f]or one [who] must also think of the *qatil* here as love of the native land; it is the strength of this love that must be tested, not only the strength of the enemy'[5], Bhagat Singh again must die. [6]

Bismil was not alone in writing like this. Sachindra Nath Sanyal, who helped establish the HRA, wrote an open letter to Gandhi chiding him. What had removed the fear of death from the hearts of Indians, he told the great Mahatma, was not Gandhianism, but the people's own belief in 'the grandeur and the beauty that lie in dying for noble causes'.[7] This is because for the HRA, the ultimate consummation of revolutionary action was to be ready to die a martyr's death for it. Bhagat Singh's own writings leave little doubt that this was his belief as well. We know this because Yadav and Singh have translated the earlier writings[8] of Bhagat Singh. From these it is clear that even as a young college student, Bhagat Singh wrote endearingly in Indian journals, such as *Kirti*, an Amritsar weekly; *Pratap*, published in Kanpur; and in *Chand*, a monthly Hindi publication, about how such shaheeds as Kartar Singh Sarabha, Madan Lal Dhingra and the Kakori martyrs had openly welcomed death. Simona Sawhney also directs our attention to 'a poem attributed to Ashfaqullah Khan [where] we read the following verse: "*Ai pukhtakhare – ulfat hoshiyar dig na jana / yan raz ashiqi hai is dar-o-rasan mein*" [Be vigilant, and do not fall, O victorious